

Trans and Queer Visibility in an Era of Hyper Surveillance: A User Experience Study of University Systems for Sharing Gender Pronouns

Journal of Technical Writing and Communication
2026, Vol. 56(1) 35–60
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DOI: 10.1177/00472816251384913
journals.sagepub.com/home/jtw



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Abstract

This paper reports on a user experience (UX) study investigating how college students navigate university-sponsored online systems for sharing chosen name and pronouns. While the opportunity to share gender identity ostensibly enables inclusive and usable systems for queer students, the visibility of gender nonconformity also imposes surveillance concerns, as pronouns have become an organizing tool for governments and university boards intent on limiting diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives. Drawing from trans and queer scholarship, this article suggests that the concept of visibility should be closely scrutinized in design settings where heightened visibility can present risks to bodily autonomy or safety.

Keywords

User experience, usability, trans theory, gender, pronouns, social justice

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Introduction

User Experience (UX) scholars have increasingly argued that our role as humanists and our commitments to social justice should enable us to advocate for digital infrastructures that attune to users' social location and the unique imbalances of power that affect vulnerable communities (e.g., Archarya, 2024a, 2024b; Donelson, 2024; Lee, 2024; McKoy et al., 2022; Rose, 2016; Sano-Franchini, 2017). These efforts have included attention to trans, queer, and gender nonconfirming communities, highlighting both the unique forms of precarity inflicted onto queer people and the tactical responses queer people have developed to subvert oppressive systems (e.g., Bear & Stone, 2021; Edenfield et al., 2019; Green, 2020; Jordan & Edenfield, 2025; Ramler, 2021). Some recent research has turned toward questions of pronoun visibility explicitly, calling on technical communicators to develop systems that account for the complexity of gender identity and grant users control over the situated nature of sharing gender identity (AleEbrahim et al., 2023). Simultaneously, though scholarship in trans and queer studies has highlighted the surveillance risks imposed by technologies that create institutional records of gender identity and make gender diversity visible to hostile audiences. As Beauchamp (2019) argues, surveillance systems that render trans existence hyper visible often work concomitantly with efforts to increase "public and state scrutiny of gender nonconformity" (p. 9). These threats have taken on greater significance recently, as years, state and federal governments have attempted to curtail diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) efforts on college campuses (refer to Bryant & Appleby, 2025; Gretzinger et al., 2025).

Extending on these conversations, this article reports on a UX study investigating how students at a large, R1 university navigate a digital infrastructure for sharing their chosen name and pronouns. The system, Student Accounts, is a self service website where students, faculty, and staff manage their personal information, financial and employment profile, and administrative records, and the university recently updated the system allowing users to share their pronouns on their profiles. I conducted remote usability tests with five trans, gender expansive, and/or nonbinary students to better understand how they navigated pronoun disclosure using Student Accounts. Considering these user experiences through the lens of security and surveillance, this article questions how the visibility of pronouns within university systems ostensibly works toward inclusion and better usability for both students and instructors. Yet the visibility of chosen names and pronouns also imposes significant security and surveillance concerns for trans and queer students, where the visibility of gender diversity can inflame potent social anxieties and subject them to increased violence or threats of erasure.

In particular, this article will highlight three findings: First, participants I spoke with personally appreciated the heightened visibility afforded by Student Accounts' system for changing their chosen names and pronouns. However, they cautioned that this same level of visibility was not consistent across trans communities, cautioning that various levels of visibility could generate greater insecurity for other trans or gender expansive students. Second, participants asked for greater clarity on how,

where, and to what extent the information on Student Accounts was visible across other systems where pronoun disclosure occurs, including university learning management systems, Zoom, and their email accounts. Last, they argued for evolving, dynamic, and responsive systems that accounted for the flexible nature of gender identity. Gender identity often emerges over time, and the language to express gender diversity continually evolves, as people find new ways to express their identity to themselves and others. The people I spoke with often encountered brittle systems or rigid discursive frameworks that limited more expansive and adaptive understandings of gender, and they recommended that the Student Accounts system could continue evolving to better reflect those perspectives.

Accordingly, this article works toward more complex understandings of UX by suggesting that design orientations that appear benevolent may have dangerous implications for structurally vulnerable communities. In the case of this study, ensuring the visibility of users' identities within a system, which may at first appear be a hallmark of more inclusive or socially just design, could compound vulnerability for some trans communities. Further, promoting the visibility of gender identity introduced concerns about how, where, and to what extent that information would be made visible across other online and offline systems, as well as questions about who had the power to control that visibility. This focus on visibility can highlight various and sometimes contradictory levels of (in)security generated by efforts for inclusive design.

Literature Review

Humanistic Approaches to UX and Asymmetries of Power

By this point, the overlaps between UX and TPC have been well documented. Following Turner and Rose (2022), I understand UX as an iterative, interdisciplinary process that seeks to better understand how technologies or systems fit into people's lives, and to design systems that respond to those dynamic lived experiences (refer also to Rose & Turner, 2024). Such approaches dedicate close attention to the context of use (Redish & Barnum, 2011), or the complex set of social, material, personal, and political factors that surround how people interact with technology. According to Turner and Rose (2022), UX also encompasses the overall effect generated by interactions between users and a system, or the outcome of a design in a person or community's life. Technical communication's longstanding focus on user advocacy and its rich theoretical understanding of audience (Johnson, 1998) align with priorities of UX, and technical communicators consistently demonstrate how the theories and methods of our field can be valuable in UX industry settings (Rose & Schreiber, 2021), and technical communicators also increasingly teach UX in their courses (refer to Gomes, 2024; Rose & Noel Turner, 2020; Rose & Turner, 2025; Turner & Rose, 2022).

Recent scholarship in technical communication has encouraged researchers to approach UX in a way that attends to complex interplays of power, culture, and positionality that inform how people interact with a system or technology. That is, as a

field, technical communication offers a humanistic lens to understand the social and ethical implications of technologies and their uses, rather than focusing on pragmatic interests like profitability, ease of use, or efficiency. Rose and Schreiber (2021), for instance, argue that the connections between technical communication and UX has evolved over time, but that TPC's unique contribution to UX is its humanistic angle, its "focus and concerns on advocacy, people, communication, and social justice" (p. 346). And in his systematic review of UX topics in TPC journals over the past ten years, Hunter (2024) suggests that TPC-focused contributions to UX coalesce around humanistic perspectives on technology, arguing that TPC adds to UX with its "attunement to networked power dynamics, its theoretically rich treatment of multimodality, and its strategies for navigating contextual complexities" (p. 324). And according to Acharya (2022), this humanistic understanding of UX asks us to focus less on system efficiency and to instead "consider usability from sociocultural orientation to accomplish sociocultural goals" (p. 6). Technical communication's established connections to user advocacy (Redish, 2010; Redish & Barnum, 2011), social justice (Rose, 2016), and human-centered design (Walton, 2016) have turned conversations about UX away from pragmatic, system-centered approaches and toward more pointed negotiations of sociocultural issues that extend beyond functionality (Acharya, 2022; Szlávi & Landoni, 2022).

UX research in TPC has also developed a particular focus on working with vulnerable communities or in addressing how design responds to asymmetries of power. Scholars in our field have long acknowledged that technologies or systems are often built with the experiences of people with greater access to structural power encoded into their design. This "default user" is defined by unquestioned assumptions about ability, race, class, age, language, and geographic location, usually in ways that reinforce the power of users with greater access to structural power. These perspectives can favor users from the global North (Acharya, 2024b); fail to account for the complexities of multilingual and multicultural global contexts of use (Acharya & Dorpenyo, 2023; Sun, 2012; Sun & Getto, 2017); ignore or oversimplify questions of disability (Zdenek, 2019); and reinforce racial biases (Benjamin, 2019; Jones et al., 2017).

Recent efforts around UX have attempted to practice new methodologies, theoretical orientations, and engagements with design that counter such tendencies and instead investigate design in a way that embraces close attention to difference, positionally, social location, and power. Working with vulnerable populations requires different methods, perspectives, and greater attention to reflection and positionality (Gonzales, 2022; Rose, 2016). In these settings, researchers must develop UX processes and methodologies that account for cultural values and local practices (Acharya, 2024a). Further, working with vulnerable communities requires researchers to reflect on the histories of extractive research leverages against communities at the margins and the way a researcher's presence may perpetuate injustice (Cardinal et al., 2020; Green et al., 2024; Tuck & Wang, 2014). Sano-Franchini (2017) describes this shift in UX perspective as one that attends "to the sociopolitical impacts of technologies by encouraging slow reflection and complex, multiperspectival thinking"

(pp. 27–28). Researchers have studied UX and interface design with vulnerable communities around concepts of health (Acharya, 2024b; Green, 2020) disability (e.g., Oswal 2019; Putnam et al., 2023); localization (Agboka, 2013; Agbozo, 2022; Gonzales & Zantjer, 2015), immigration (Chen et al., 2025), and community-based collaborations (e.g., Gonzales, 2022; Lee et al., 2023; Shivers-McNair et al., 2019).

Taken together, these perspectives have turned our field away for questions of how easily, efficiently, or quickly users can complete tasks and instead toward questioning how the relationships between people, technologies, and use fit within complex social dynamics and trenchant inequality. They push TPC scholars to center cultural factors, local contexts of use, and deep understandings of power, rather than mere efficiency. Crucially, they also affirm that technical communicators, who are trained to attend to issues of user advocacy, are well poised to take on projects where technology design intersects with imbalances in power or where system navigate contentious social issues with material implications for user safety or autonomy.

UX, Gender, and a Trans Politics of Visibility

In this article, I take up UX and TPC's established frameworks for studying power, vulnerability, and sociocultural approaches to technology design as it relates to gender pronoun disclosure. While TPC research has offered rich and productive frameworks for researching around contentious social issues and within contexts of vulnerability, I want to situate this project more explicitly in relationship trans scholarship around the concept of visibility. In design settings, visibility can be considered a universal benefit or a benevolent effort to ensure that users' bodies and lived experiences are rendered legible by system designs. By prioritizing visibility, resulting interfaces or systems can better align with users' goals and identities. This perspective often informs efforts for more inclusive design. For instance, in its guide for adding pronouns to user profiles, Zoom claims that "Pronouns are an essential piece to many of our diverse users expressing themselves and respectfully referring to others.... pronoun sharing enables our users to better share about themselves and be more respectfully treated on our platform" (2023, n.p.). And while research around pronouns from a UX perspective is relatively limited, recent research has used UX methods to develop systems that are better responsive to gender diversity (e.g., Ale-Ebrahim et al. 2023; Wang et al., 2024). Amiri et al. (2024), for instance, found that incorporating wider options for gender identification can improve system usability for gender non-conforming audiences, arguing, "as society progresses towards greater recognition and acceptance of diverse gender identities, it is imperative that [user interface] design evolves to reflect these values of inclusivity and respect" (p. 79).

However, scholarship in trans and queer theory has pushed toward more complex understandings of how visibility within a system affects trans communities. Mia Fischer (2019) argues that while increased visibility was a persuasive and successful political strategy in gay and lesbian liberation movements, increased visibility and representation has not led to belonging or liberation for trans people in the same way.

Drawing from Foucault, Fischer argues, “While greater media visibility and recognition are often seen as a measure of cultural justice and social equality, they can also produce a pathway to biopolitical management, promoting techniques of surveillance, self-monitoring, and self-responsibility for marginalized communities” (p. 14). For Fischer, visibility offers a limited pathway for social equality, as heightened visibility has also enabled a conservative backlash that has resulted in increased surveillance and even reinforced cisnormative conceptions of gender and sexuality. Edenfield et al. (2019a, 2019b) echoed concerns around visibility for trans communities. After a news article about one of the online forums in their study was published, “Users expressed dismay at how they were represented and feared the article would bring unwanted attention and threaten their ability to access necessary medication” (2019b, p. 185). While Edenfield et al. (2019b) use the anecdote to highlight methodological complexities of researching with trans communities, it illustrates the compounding vulnerabilities that can be imposed by increased visibility within digital public spheres.

In a discussion with Toshio Meronek and Miss Major Griffin Gracy, Cece McDonald affirms the perils associated with increased visibility, writing

“With the height of trans visibility has also come the height of trans violence and murder. And so it’s very important for people to acknowledge that yes, it is important to see these figures in the spotlights, but it is also necessary to recognize that this ‘trans tipping point’ is bringing an unsettling rate of violence toward trans women” (Griffin-Gracy et al., 2017, p. 26)

Further, in their analysis of project 2025’s policy priorities, Quinan (2025) argues that trans visibility has given way not just to physical violence or attacks on trans people, but to broader forms of administrative violence (refer to Spade, 2015) that seek to “erase transness from public life” (p.4). These patterns impact those who merely appear to be threats, and they agitate acute social anxieties around gender nonconformity regardless of any wrongdoing. This agitation subjects them to greater scrutiny, greater surveillance, and stripping of civil rights. These perspectives show how visibility works in tandem or alongside state systems of surveillance and control which subject trans bodies to increased scrutiny and punishment.

This tension—between creating inclusive design and managing the visibility of potentially sensitive personal information—is especially relevant today, given that chosen names and pronouns have become a political organizing tool for state and local governments intent on limiting the import of DEI initiatives on college campuses (Farrington, 2023; Goldstein, 2023; Gupton & O’Sullivan, 2024; Wiessner, 2024), and university boards have taken aim at diversity and inclusion offices and prohibited discussion of gender or sexuality (Anderson, 2023; Anderson & Gecker, 2023; Hollingsworth, 2023; Wiessner, 2024). For instance, In Idaho, the state board of education approved a resolution banning DEI on college campuses, a ban that, along with shuttering universities’ multicultural student centers, prevents colleges from requiring students or staff to share their preferred pronouns (Richert, 2024; Smith, 2024). In

2024, two staff members at the University of South Dakota were forced to remove their gender pronouns and tribal affiliations from their email signatures (Fouriezos, 2024) after the state's Board of Regents restricted the information that could be included in official university communications (South Dakota Board of Regents, 2023). And educators in Florida have sued the state board of education after they were terminated for sharing their pronouns with students (Kam, 2024). Further, in February 2025, Iowa governor Kim Reynolds signed a bill removing gender identity as a protected class in the state's civil rights law, stripping trans people of protections in housing, employment, education (Fadel, 2025; Gruber-Miller et al., 2025). The legislation closely mirrored language in one of the first executive orders Donald Trump signed in January 2025, which defined gender universally as a male/female binary (The White House, 2025).

I don't want to oversimplify the concept of visibility in relation to trans identities and gender expansiveness in digital spheres. There is an extensive history of trans organization, activism, and tactical forms of resistance deployed online to counter restrictive notions of gender, promote access to resources, cultivate identity, and reinforce community bonds. The tension around visibility has more to do with power, in determining who has the power to leverage gender nonconformity's visibility to agitate social anxieties, amass political power, and enable physical and structural violence against trans people. And this attention to visibility calls into question the epistemological and cultural foundations that enable dehumanizing responses to gender difference, where the visibility of gender nonconformity is so often used to cement an ideology that treats trans life as disposable or as evidence of pathology, rather than generating broader public acceptance. These interventions from queer and trans scholars point our field toward a contextually specific understanding of visibility in design settings, one that attends to the co-constitutive nature of visibility and precarity for trans communities, what Gill-Peterson (2018) describes as the "convergence of trans visibility and vulnerability" (P. 196).

Methods

This study contributes to these ongoing conversations around UX, queer and trans visibility, and security studies pursuing the following research question: How do students at a large, R1, public university navigate online infrastructures for sharing their chosen name and pronouns? To investigate this question, I used synchronous remote usability testing methods. Synchronous remote usability testing has a long history in usability studies (Dray & Siegel, 2004; Thompson et al., 2004), and it entails meeting with a study participant using a video conferencing software, asking participants to test real scenarios using their own devices, and recording the interactions. Synchronous usability testing takes advantage of video conferencing, screen sharing, and screen recording technologies to observe participants navigate online systems (Alhadreti, 2022). These methods also recreate environments that closely mirror actual contexts of use, as participants complete the tests in their home environments using their own devices, and

they often ease logistic and time burdens (Straand et al., 2024). While some have found slight differences between remote and in-person usability testing, including changes in error rates and time on task (Thompson et al., 2004), others suggest that synchronous remote usability testing offers nearly all the affordances as laboratory-based tests (Sauer et al., 2019).

As I suggested in the literature review, TPC and UX scholars have shown that traditional usability methods can offer limited perspectives on the role technology plays in people's lives and can prioritize metrics like efficiency and ease of use over deeper questions about power, access, justice, ethics, community advocacy, or participant autonomy and agency (Rose, 2022). To account for these limitations, TPC researchers have embraced mixed, multidisciplinary, and innovative methods for UX settings (Lanius et al., 2021), including video diary studies (Rose, 2016), ethnographies (Tofteland-Trampe, 2017), community partnerships (Rose et al., 2017; Shivers-McNair et al., 2019), or participatory approaches (Gonzales, 2022; Rose & Cardinal, 2018). Yet task-based usability studies are still used in the field (Lanius et al., 2021) and can be useful to test existing interfaces (e.g., Cooke, 2010; Kessler et al., 2021). Further, coupling the usability test with broader interview questions can help better situate digital systems within their constitutive social, political, and geographic contexts and allow for richer understandings of users' experiences as they relate to social conditions (Sibley et al., 2022)

The usability tests for this study focus on Student Accounts², a self-service website where students, faculty, and staff manage their personal information, financial and employment profile, and administrative records. Student Accounts recently introduced a feature allowing users to update their chosen name and pronouns, allowing students, faculty, and staff an option to input their chosen name, gender identity, and to select their pronouns from a list of options. The selection offers a dropdown of 16 options, including combinations of he, she, and they pronouns as well as "none" or "name only."

I recruited participants by asking instructors to distribute a call to their classes and by asking other faculty and staff who work in student support services to distribute the call to their listservs. While I did not place restrictions on participants' gender identity, all the participants who volunteered for the study described themselves as trans, non-binary, or gender expansive, or they indicated that their pronouns did not fall into binary categories of he/him/his or she/her/hers. This participant pool could have resulted from limited recruitment efforts on my part, or they could reflect my own involvement with queer organizing groups, student success organizations on campus, and university life offices.

In total, I recruited five students to participate in the study: Blake, (he/ze); Ash (they/she); Willow (they/them); John (they/them); Jess (they/them). When I met with these people, I told them that I would use a pseudonym to refer to their quotations in any articles or reports that resulted from our conversation, and I asked if they had a pseudonym they would like me to use. Three of the five participants chose their own pseudonyms: Jess, Willow, and John. I chose the other two: Ash and Blake. All the

participants were either undergraduate or graduate students at the university, and four of the five participants (all but Jess) had familiarity with the Student Accounts system, either from updating their pronouns in the past or from working in campus organizing around trans visibility. While I explicitly asked participants about their pronouns, I did not collect information about other elements of their social location (i.e., race, income status, age). I wanted participants to control how and to what extent they situated their pronoun disclosure in relationship to other intersections of power and identity, rather than intuiting, assuming, or suggesting those connections myself.

After recruiting participants and scheduling the usability tests and interviews, I met over zoom with participants and, consistent with usability testing practices, asked them to complete a task on the interface. I presented users with the following scenario and task:

You are a student at [redacted] University, and you want to update your pronouns or chosen name so that your professors know how to refer to you in class. Using [Student Accounts], how would you change your chosen name or pronouns? Note: For this study, you do not need to complete the name or pronoun change. Just go as far as you can without officially submitting any changes.

I also encouraged think-aloud protocols during the test; I asked participants to vocalize their thoughts, behaviors, questions, frustrations, or ideas as they were navigating Student Accounts. Participants also shared their screens while completing the task, and I took notes on their behaviors and any visual or verbal indications about their experiences.

After each usability test, I asked a series of semistructured interview questions to better understand their experiences with Student Accounts and to situate this online system within other contexts for pronoun disclosure in instructional settings. I asked:

1. In general, how easy or difficult was it to update this information?
2. When you have been in classes in the past, how have you shared your chosen name or pronoun with your instructor?
3. When you have been in classes in the past, how have you shared your chosen name or pronouns with other students?
4. Can you tell me about a time when you've been a student and gender pronouns came up in class?
5. Do you have any concerns about the security or privacy of information about your gender identity when you share that information with professors? Or when you share that information on Student Accounts?

The interview protocol also included opportunities for follow-up questions based on participants reflections during the think-aloud protocol and their responses to the interview questions. At the end of the interview, instead of asking participants a general

question about other information they would like to share, I asked the following question:

My pronouns align with the gender I was assigned at birth, and that lens affects how I move through the world, including how I designed and implemented this study. From your perspective, are there any questions you think I should be asking or ideas I should be focusing on around this topic of pronoun disclosure in instructional settings?

I saw this question as a useful counter to social scientific and UX practices that position the researcher as an abstract, de-raced, de-gendered objective observer, and instead emphasized that my unique social location as a gay, White, cis man impacted the assumptions I projected onto this study. Such a question is perhaps a superficial methodological tool to counter histories of harmful research practices used against trans communities, but it explicitly situated my inquiry within my own positionality and invited participants to identify questions, concerns or gaps that my own research design may have missed.

I conducted five usability tests and interviews with current university students between February and March 2025, each lasting between 20 and 40 min. I conducted the usability tests and interviews over Zoom and used Zoom's screen sharing and recording features to observe participants and capture video recordings, audio files, and written transcripts. Because the video recording had the potential to capture sensitive or personally identifiable information, I deleted the video file after the audio and transcript files had been generated. After each interview, I wrote a brief reflective memo detailing participants' nonverbal interactions during the usability test and noting any significant quotations, behaviors, and insights that came up during our conversation. These memos, the audio file from the interview, and the transcript constituted the data collected for this study.

To analyze the data, I used a combination of inductive and deductive thematic analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006), a method which involves assigning codes to sections of language from qualitative data (think aloud and interview responses) or behavioral patterns (those I gathered from the usability tests). Thematic analysis is a systematic process designed to identify patterns in qualitative data, both capturing underlying themes and clarifying latent theories (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Because of current conversations around how visibility affects surveillance and criminalization for trans communities, I deductively coded interviews for participants' perceptions on security concerns associated with making their pronouns visible or viewable within Student Accounts to better understand how participants contend with the risks associated with pronoun disclosure. This means I deductively coded for moments in the interviews when participants discussed concepts related to visibility, like security of information, openness about their identity to others, outing, or doxxing. For example, one participant told me "I feel as a source of empowerment, visibility really is important," which I coded as "visibility and empowerment." Another participant said, "if there does end up being a government registry that tries to find trans people, they could use that information,"

which I coded as “visibility and security.” Because I specifically asked participants to reflect on security concerns associated with Student Accounts, all participants in some way discussed visibility.

I also inductively coded for themes that emerged from the interviews and usability tests beyond my own research questions. From the inductive coding, I identified two additional themes: “visibility and data security across other systems” and “dynamic/flexible systems for pronoun disclosure.” For the visibility and data security across other systems theme, I coded for instances when participants discussed other systems or instructional settings aside from Student Accounts that impacted their pronoun disclosure, including mentions of online learning management systems, offline interactions with instructors, or practices for indicating their pronouns outside of student accounts. For the dynamic/flexible systems for pronoun disclosure theme, I coded for instances when participants discussed how gender identity emerges over time and often reflects personal and community development. Those more fluid conceptions of gender existed in tension with systems or instructional practices which tended to reflect static or binary understandings of gender and confined participants’ abilities to express their full personhood. In the inductive coding process, I performed three rounds of coding to identify and affirm emergent codes, which led to the two additional themes I found from speaking with participants.

While the coding process I employed was a systematic process designed to identify emergent themes, I was also guided by my own social location as a queer person and my own ideals grounded in social justice. That is, my conclusions in this article were not a mere objective observation of data but were also guided by ideals of justice and critiquing oppressive power structures, as well as the common ground participants and I shared as members of the queer community. So, while the themes I saw in the study reflected a systematic process of data analysis, it also emerged from collective commitments to queer advocacy on campus and a broader social justice perspective that seeks critique systems of power that harm the most vulnerable.

Findings

Results from Usability Test

Four of the five completed the usability test with relative ease. Blake, whose pronouns are he/ze pronouns, was an expert user and had worked closely with the gender resource center on campus to update gender pronoun options on Student Accounts. Ze completed the test in three minutes and 27 s—though much of that time was extended by their think-aloud commentary—and experienced no issues. Ash user navigated to three wrong menu items before finding the correct “personal information” link, which was hidden below the fold of the page. They completed the task in two minutes and 30 s. Willow (they/them) was also an expert user and completed the task in a minute and 14 s. They indicated, though, that the process had changed and the drop-down had more options for pronouns than the first time they updated their information.

The fourth participant, John (they/them), completed the task in 39 s, though they indicated that they had looked into this process in advance after they saw the recruitment email. They had also completed this process already in a transition to college course (a one-credit elective designed for first-year students).

One of the five participants, though, experienced more significant challenges. At the beginning of the test, Jess (they/them) indicated that they were “not even thinking about [Student Accounts], because I don’t use it ever hardly.” Instead, they first went to their email and looked on the menus in mail for about 30 s, saying “I usually end up spending a half an hour to an hour, just looking these things over again, because I can never remember what they do.” Then Jess went to the campus’ LMS, spent 4 min and 15 s trying to obtain a bypass code to log into the LMS, which included logging in to their personal email account, answering security questions, obtaining a code, locating the original LMS window, and conducting a dual-factor authorization before successfully logging in. Jess spent another minute and a half searching menus on the LMS for a place to update their pronouns. Eventually, Jess said, “A person [at a different university] told me that if I want to change my name and any other personal information I should plug in ‘Call me by my name.’” At that point, Jess opened a new browser window and typed “Call me by my name” and the name of their university, where they found a university guide for updating chosen name and pronouns. By the time Jess was able to log into Student Accounts, they quickly found the personal information tab and the option to update their pronouns. While it took Jess a total of 11 min and two seconds to complete the task, after logging in to Student Accounts, it took Jess one minute and 51 s to find and update their pronouns.

Jess’s narrative could point toward further usability questions, like investigating how and where students learn about the option to update their pronouns using Student Accounts. Further, Jess is a nontraditional student; they told me that they worked in their home for about 15 years before returning to college a few years ago, and they were currently enrolled part time at two different universities. This perspective could raise usability questions about how nontraditional students interact with campus information systems or how they find support services. What’s more, Jess’ story could illuminate the information literacy practices that circulate among students to navigate these systems, a set of tactical networks for sharing information which may complicate or contrast dominant pathways for publicizing Student Accounts’ features. While Jess’ experience invites a range of other inquiries, Jess and the rest of the participants I spoke to indicated that the system posed no significant usability problems and that they could update their personal information to reflect their accurate chosen name and pronouns. These findings could have resulted from the small sample and the participants’ familiarity with the process.

Visibility

Despite the relative ease of use indicated by the usability tests, participants’ interview responses and think aloud reflections surfaced other UX concerns. When I analyzed interview data, I deductively coded for participant’s responses to identify how they

thought about visibility and information security. I was interested in knowing how participants negotiated the complex political and interpersonal terrain around the visibility of pronouns, particularly given political efforts to surveil and control trans existence. The participants I spoke with acknowledged concerns about visibility but indicated that risks associated with sharing their pronouns were outweighed by the benefits of visibility.

Blake brought up the importance of visibility in their think aloud protocol, so, during the interview, I asked them if they had any concerns about visibility as it relates to privacy or security. They said, for them, the visibility was a benefit, explaining “Activism and advocacy is where I really started, and I have found a way to blend that into my scholar-ness or my academic-ness. Part of the activism in me, is this is one thing I won’t budge on.” They went on to discuss how important visibility was for them and for others in the community:

I feel as a source of empowerment, visibility really is important ... Being present with my new pronouns is that visibility that other students may need. Other folks in the community may wish to see [me] or have that sense of community or connection together. So for me, I personally don’t have any feelings of pressure. If anything, I double down harder, because that’s not something I’m budging on. I’m not budging on who I am as a person. I’m not going to budge on my values that stand with me as my lived experiences have shaped me on who I am today.

Blake’s response illustrates that visibility may cause concerns for some in the community, yet for them, any efforts to criminalize, surveil, or otherwise diminish the visibility of trans life leads them to redouble their commitment to being publicly visible. Blake’s response suggested that they did not internalize the logics of surveillance, fear, or dehumanization that motivate federal, state, or local action aimed at legislating trans people out of existence. Instead, Blake saw visibility as a way of “doubling down” or pushing back against efforts to render trans life invisible or illegible. Their assertion that “I’m not budging on who I am as a person” suggests that while Blake may recognize the threats of legislation or political efforts to diminish trans visibility, they were not going to cede power to those forces.

This sentiment, that visibility was a benefit to participants, was relatively consistent across my interviews. I asked Ash if they had concerns about security or privacy when sharing their pronouns on Student Accounts, and Ash said,

I don’t. I am very lucky that I don’t like. I have a very accepting family. I am in a position where, I am out at my work. I’m also out, and all that. So, I’m not really at risk of being outed to people.

While Ash felt secure at this point, they also expressed concerns about implications of visibility for other trans people and for the future. They said:

But there's also kind of like part of me is a little bit concerned that like, if there does end up being like a government registry that tries to find trans people right that they could use that information. And granted, like, I am incredibly open about that side of myself, so that, like it wouldn't be [Student Accounts] where they would find it, they'd find it on like Instagram or something

Like Ash, Willow thought that their pronouns were already visible and publicly available online, so the information the put into Student Accounts did not impact their fears of security. Willow said, "in terms of like my public online presence, I've had some articles that are on [the university's] website. They have my pronouns and at this point, it would be very difficult to take those down." And John indicated a similar experience, saying, "I don't have any professors who like I'd be worried about having that information, so I don't have any real concerns about that. If like, in a theoretical scenario." These are important experiences, because they signal that while participants are aware of the current or potential threats to trans communities, the participants I spoke with did not internalize the gaze of surveillance or cede power to legislative or procedural efforts to eliminate trans life in their pronoun disclosure preferences.

All the participants I spoke with cautioned, though, that these perspectives on visibility were not universal, blanket assumptions that could be applied to all trans individuals or all situations where people navigated sharing their pronouns. When I asked Blake about security and visibility, they said, "that question is going to be different for every trans and gender expansive individual who navigates these spaces." Even though the participants I spoke with did not harbor significant concerns about the visibility of their pronouns on Student Accounts, they cautioned for a dynamic, flexible approach to designing systems for gender pronoun disclosure where pronoun disclosure was a situated, personally and contextually dependent process.

Jess, for instance, had no concerns sharing their pronouns on Student Accounts. In fact, they took pride in sharing their pronouns with their professors, and they asked if I could use their chosen name instead of a pseudonym for this article, saying "I want you to use my name ... I really love it!" Yet they expressed other concerns about making their personal information visible online. They said:

since I started using Internet 15 or 20 years ago, I was writing on the Internet and going to chat rooms, and then I would start using fake information because it's online that I'm concerned about it. [I'm] typing in fake information all the time online, I type in fake birthdates, fake names. I have multiple email accounts that I use for different reasons. And some I use when I'm concerned about security because they cannot trace me. But I'm constantly navigating and trying to decide when I can use fake information and when I have to use real information. So yeah, it's a constant concern.

This response points to the situated nature of pronoun disclosure and the tactical responses that many trans and gender expansive people deploy to protect privacy online. Jess, for instance, made calculated decisions about what information was

safe to share on Student Accounts and in instructional settings, while also acknowledging that they constantly assess where and to what extent they make their personal information visible to wider online communities. What's important in this situation is that Jess maintained a level of autonomy and agency to control how their information was made visible and to whom, or they found ways to subvert surveilling practices and data sharing policies online. This same level of agency and autonomy are not always guaranteed, calling into question the systems of privacy in place around sharing gender identity. Further, in the case of this study, questions of visibility extend beyond individual privacy controls; instead, the presence of the chosen name and pronoun system on Student Accounts itself, which allows for expansive expressions of gender, can motivate violent responses from groups intent on limiting educational institutions' capacity to recognize gender difference. These responses point toward more culturally situated forms of security, privacy, and digital surveillance that reflect the unique conditions of visibility for queer and trans students.

Visibility and Data Security Across Other Systems

Participants indicated that there was a lack of clarity around how the information they input into Student Accounts appeared or was made visible elsewhere, particularly in other digital infrastructures like Zoom, email, or the campus LMS where participants said that pronoun disclosure was important. During the usability test, Jess expressed frustration that they didn't know how or where their pronoun information appeared outside of Student Accounts. As they selected their pronouns from the dropdown, they said, "Pronouns, they/them/theirs. Okay, I want that. I have no idea where that shows up anywhere. It doesn't, as far as I can see and where I want it to show up is on my Zoom account." Jess went on to say, "where I put my pronouns on Student Accounts has nothing to do with what shows up when I enter a Zoom class." I asked Jess why Zoom was more important for them than our campus registration website, and they said "Zoom's the only place I see it. It's updated on Student Accounts. I have no idea where that's showing up. It's not showing up on Blackboard. It's not showing up in my mail."

Even John, who navigated to Student Accounts and found the option to update pronouns quickly, indicated that Student Accounts was not their first instinct. Instead, they said:

my first thought, when it comes to like changing pronouns, would be through Blackboard or Canvas, considering that's where I'm posting my assignments, my information or talking on the Canvas discussion board in order to interact with other students. And that's where I'd assume like people would be able to see my profile and my pronouns.

In addition to updating their pronouns on the university's learning management system, John indicated that they referred to the pronoun system on Canvas when they interacted with another student. They said, "I remember I was in an online Zoom class ... I

pulled up the Canvas discussion board that we were talking about and referring to someone's point. I didn't know their immediate pronouns because we didn't interact that much personally. But their Canvas profile, had their pronouns on it. So, I referred to them using that." John's response suggests that they, like Jess, would not think of Student Accounts as the first place to find information about pronouns, and that there is a lack of clarity around how the information in Student Accounts translates across other university systems.

For other participants, there was a lack of clarity around how professors saw or internalized information. Willow described being misgendered by a professor and placed that experience in the context of having updated their pronouns on Student Accounts:

having gone through the process of changing them in [Student Accounts] and then having professors use he/him because that's sort of what I look like. It does make me question if that's a willful disconnection, or if that's like an error in the process somewhere.

This experience, where Willow was clear about their pronouns on Student Accounts but was misgendered in class, mirrored their experience with other analog technologies for pronoun disclosure. They said, when I wear a pronoun button, there have been cases where the professors still don't use the right pronouns. Still there is like a tiny benefit of the doubt of like, maybe they just didn't look or pay attention. While Willow seems to want to give professors the benefit of the doubt, their experience called into question the extent to which information on Student Accounts was visible to professors. Jess echoed this sentiment, saying,

when I started using [my chosen name] and changing my pronouns it felt so much better. It felt more like me, you know, and but people, when they hear my voice, they see my face. A lot of people. Still, even if the pronouns are up there, refer to me as she. This happened two days ago at [another university]. A professor did that when he had no reason to.

These experiences, on one hand, raise questions about the extent to which instructors, advisers, and other university affiliates access information about student's chosen names and pronouns, which is unfortunately outside the scope of this study. The responses also raise questions, though, about the underlying normative value systems in place, where instructors often make assumptions about student's gender identities and project binary categorizations onto their interactions with students. These experiences indicate that Student Accounts is part of a larger network of ideological perspectives on gender, instructional technologies, and instructional practices that affect students' experiences, and meaningfully accounting for those experiences requires more expansive methods and investigation beyond a narrow focus on individual technologies.

Dynamic and Flexible Systems for Pronoun Disclosure

In addition to visibility across systems, some participants described how they encountered systems, situations, and interpersonal instructional settings that reflected a rigid, brittle, or binary perspective on gender. This perspective conflicted with participants' experiences, which positioned pronoun visibility as a flexible, dynamic process that reflects how gender and identity change over time. Blake said, "I consistently have to reinforce the folks that it's fluid, too, right? I think honoring right the fact that folks' pronouns may change throughout their time of doing identity development of solidifying that for themselves. It may look different at a different time. And that's okay, right?" This ongoing, flexible process of identification came up across my conversations with students. Ash, for instance, said: last time I went, I used they/she pronouns, which was not one of the listed options ... And so luckily, I emailed [an administrator] and they helped me get they/she in there." For Ash, one of the strengths of the Student Accounts system was that it could adapt and change over time in ways that aligned with their gender identity.

Ash and I spoke about how they experienced this brittle concept of gender in their classes. Ash said, "I have seen some tensions happen there, where certain professors aren't really aware of that sort of a distinction." I asked them if there was a particular time where they saw a professor grapple with those distinctions. Ash replied:

[one of my friends] was in a group of people where one of the people was very comfortable with sharing their dead name ... At some point the professor ... shared [my friend's] dead name, and he was very uncomfortable with that. And so, it was a space of like one person felt one way about it. So, the professor kind of assumed that that was how everybody felt about it and then accidentally outed this other student's dead name.

Ash's response highlights the rigid perspectives that often accompany pronoun disclosure, where this instructor assumed that one students' openness or perspective on deadnaming could be applied for all their trans students. Ash's response instead calls for flexibility, fluidity, and ongoing learning to navigate pronoun disclosure.

During the usability test, Willow navigated Student Account system easily. When they got to the pronoun dropdown menu, they said "oh, they have more options!" During the follow-up interview, I asked Willow if the menu was different from the last time they were there. They said "it was just he/him/his, she/hers, they/them/theirs. Those [were] the 3 options." I asked them if they would have chosen different pronouns in the past, if they had the same options that were available now. They said, "if I had those options before, it would have been like he/they and then they/theirs." Willow told me that their pronouns were initially he/him, and as they went through identity development, they started using they/he, and then eventually they/them. For Willow, the ongoing flexibility of the Student Accounts system was a benefit.

At the end of our interview, John brought up the topic of neopronouns. They said, "there's this entire debacle in the entire trans community regarding neopronouns." I

asked John how the list of pronoun options on Student Accounts could reflect current conversations around neopronouns. John said,

I've seen people argue against neopronouns [because] the introduction of them makes it too difficult to keep track of who's who. And overall it makes things way too diverse and complex for it to be like, easy to talk to, and it kind of goes against the whole idea of trying to make comfortable safe places by driving people out because they don't want to interact with that because of one reason or another.

John's perspective on neopronouns illustrates the ongoing, flexible, and dynamic nature of pronoun disclosure and the ongoing nature of identity development. While they cautioned that including neopronouns in the Student Account list of options would have to be a "wanted change" among people in the community, their perspective reflects how static systems around pronouns could fail to reflect current conversations around pronoun disclosure.

In some ways, students' commentaries about the flexibility of gender—and the anxieties that surface when they express the unfixed nature of identity—could point toward deeper tendencies to make identity knowable by imposing rigid barriers around how people can express themselves, or to create brittle digital infrastructures that don't allow for ongoing change, development, and personal growth. These experiences suggest that the development of Student Accounts pronoun disclosure interface must be part of a larger, ongoing process for system development, instructor support or professional development, and changes in beliefs that would support more flexible understandings of gender that evolve over time.

Conclusion

These findings suggest that participants balanced dynamic, situationally dependent relationships around the visibility of their pronouns, and that while the Student Accounts System worked for them, the levels of visibility afforded by the system apply differently for different trans or gender expansive people. These conclusions, though, could be limited in a number of ways. It is a relatively small study, and four of the five participants had some familiarity with the Student Accounts system already. Further, participants' responses suggested that Student Accounts existed in a network of other instructional technologies, offline processes for sharing name and pronouns, and interactions with professors. As a result, further investigation could reveal how instructors, professors, advisers, or other university affiliates navigated Student Accounts as part of the process of learning their students' pronouns or sharing their pronouns with students, and other methodological frameworks (like diary studies or observations) could lend greater insight on the dispersed and situational nature of sharing names and pronouns. Additionally, of course, students in other states, universities, or stages of identity development could navigate pronoun disclosure quite differently, based on local political contexts, familial power dynamics, and differing levels of social hostility toward the trans community.

Despite these potential limitations, this study contributes to ongoing conversations in UX, technical communication, and queer and trans scholarship in a few ways. In particular, this study reveals the importance of taking an interdisciplinary approach when studying UX around issues of power and vulnerability. In this case, it was infeasible to understand how gender and pronoun visibility operated in participants' experiences without also understanding the complex politics around trans visibility that scholars in gender and sexuality studies have put forward, nor was it possible to separate those politics of visibility from the contentious, violent social and cultural setting that renders trans life through the lens of pathology and deviance. Focusing on the concept of visibility as it is theorized in trans scholarship allowed me to question how well-intentioned design efforts, including those grounded in inclusive gender and sexuality ideals, may paradoxically heighten insecurity for already vulnerable groups and perpetuate opportunities for increased state surveillance of gender nonconformity.

For technical communicators and UX designers, this interdisciplinary approach could help develop studies and methodologies that better account for how social location and power inform complex contexts of use. So often, designers and technical communicators focused on concepts like vulnerability or social justice can start working in communities with no or relatively little background on issues that have propelled activism or significant scholarship in those communities. Taking time to investigate topics, concepts, and ideas central to the communities intended to benefit from better UX can help attune researchers to social concerns that are not readily apparent to those outside the community. I should note, it's rarely possible to account fully for the power imbalances that permeate research settings or to eliminate our blind spots as researchers. For instance, even though I am a queer person who has worked closely with campus organizations focused on gender and sexuality, I still am not part of the trans community, and there is a base of knowledge and experience there that I will never have and will never claim to have. But listening to scholars from outside our field and situating those conversations against technical communication and UX scholarship can surface the complex political histories behind certain terms and design decisions stemming from those terms. Without attending to these tensions, UX researchers stand to recreate conditions of vulnerability under the auspices of more inclusive design or pursue questions and methodologies that reinforce harmful conditions.

There are a variety of research practices that could support such an approach. Scholars might begin by mapping their own social locations and political commitments before beginning a project or use their own location within a community as a starting point for designing UX studies. Scholars might also look to research and activism from within the community to better understand central terms, concepts, or ideas before designing a study. Further, structuring openness, reflection, and flexibility into methodological protocols may support a research infrastructure that better emphasizes mutual and co-constitutive expertise between researchers and participants. While only starting points, these decisions may point the field toward less harmful design practices and call into question the seemingly neutral, stable, or tacit assumptions that filter into UX settings, revealing new orientations for supporting human autonomy and agency through research in the field.

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Funding

The author received no financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Declaration of Conflicting Interests

The author declared no potential conflicts of interest with respect to the research, authorship, and/or publication of this article.

Notes

1. To protect anonymity, “Student Accounts” is a pseudonym for the website.
2. To protect anonymity, “Student Accounts” is a pseudonym for the website.

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